

Normal

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“Normal,” because of its easy associations with typical, ordinary, or unremarkable, appears to many people as a benign word, nothing more than a neutral descriptor of certain groups, bodies, or behaviors that are more common than others. Yet more than almost any other keyword in American studies and cultural studies, “normal” carries with it a history of discursive and literal violence against those who could never hope to be described by the term. Sexual minorities, disabled people, racialized populations, immigrants, and many others have at times found themselves among the motley group that the Chicana lesbian feminist Gloria Anzaldúa terms *los atravesados*: “those who cross over, pass over, or go through the confines of the ‘normal’” (1987, 3). For Anzaldúa and innumerable other critics of the normal, this border crossing has consequences. Lives lived beyond the confines of the normal have been marked as illegitimate and targeted for surveillance, control, correction, confinement, and even elimination.

The history of the keyword “normal” is relatively short compared to that of most words in the English language, despite the fact that the term structures contemporary cultures in powerful and nearly ubiquitous ways. The Oxford English Dictionary (OED) notes that the idea of “normal” as “constituting or conforming to a type or standard; regular, usual, typical; ordinary, conventional” was not in common usage until 1840. This usage roughly coincides with the French statistician [Adolphe Quetelet's \(1835\)](#) widely influential notion of *l'homme moyen*, or average man, an abstract human being with particular qualities that could be measured and graphed. Characteristics that were “abnormal,” according to the new understandings of statistics developed by Quetelet and others, were those located outside a “normal” bell-shaped curve ([L. Davis 1995](#)). Over the course of the nineteenth century, statistical measurement became an imperative: not only could human characteristics be observed and plotted on graphs and charts, but they should be, in order to identify (and potentially correct) that which was abnormal ([L. Davis 1995](#)).

By the end of the century, this imperative produced a second usage traced in the OED of “normal” as descriptive of a person “physically and mentally sound; free from any disorder; healthy.” Here, the word's appearance of carrying mere statistical meaning (as average or mean) masks its ability to bear moral judgment and to privilege certain groups (as normal) while subordinating others (as deviant). Only at the beginning of the twentieth century did the term begin to name a person who might be understood as “heterosexual” (a term that itself was coined only in 1868) ([J. Katz 1995](#)). In less than a century, then, a word with a Latin etymology that meant “conforming to or organized by a rule” began to carry, in most European languages, dominant meanings that Anzaldúa and other scholars of American studies and cultural studies now critique.

Across this history, the normal was not simply being identified and described; rather, as the philosopher Michel Foucault makes clear, an entire culture and machinery of “normalization” were emerging.

Normalization entailed the widespread production of knowledge and discourse about those who were “abnormal.” Technologies of normalization developed over the nineteenth century. These technologies, ranging from medical or psychiatric charts to judicial records, targeted “dangerous individuals” who deviated from a standard, or “norm,” and on whom corrective power thus needed to be exercised ([Foucault 1999/2003](#)). Normalizing power, in these contexts, is not simply repressive; it works by producing ways of knowing, recognizing, and categorizing individuals. Power is therefore best understood as a relation, as something always in motion, rather than an inert substance or property. Put differently, power is not simply held by one privileged group and exercised on another, weaker or “disempowered,” group. Instead, power is at work everywhere, constructing—literally materializing—normal and abnormal subjects.

Discourses of normalcy and abnormalcy were generated in, and traveled through, institutions such as schools, prisons, asylums, and hospitals and were codified by the “expert opinion” of people authorized by such institutions. Enforcing normalcy and identifying and containing abnormalcy were particularly important for an emerging industrial capitalist order, which needed the majority of people to function as able-bodied laborers in a “work-based” rather than a “need-based” system. Tests, measurements, questionnaires, and other “validating devices” shaped by a range of authorities (doctors, psychiatrists, government officials, insurance agents) were developed both to keep the majority of normal people in the work-based system and to stigmatize those sorted, through a newly invented “clinical concept of disability,” into the need-based system ([D. Stone 1984](#)). These processes did more than make the association of “normal” and “able-bodied” appear to be completely natural. Over the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, they required that disabled people—those forced to appeal to the very institutions that had deemed them abnormal and dependent—had to pass through “ceremonies of social degradation” to demonstrate their eligibility for the work-based system ([L. Davis 1995](#); [Longmore 2003](#)).

Flourishing throughout the nineteenth century and into the twentieth, freak shows, which put on display people with congenital disabilities and racialized groups, made abnormalcy spectacular in a somewhat different way. Freaks were constructed through a discursive transformation of individual (and otherwise unremarkable) characteristics: William Henry Johnson, an African American man with a cognitive disability, became the “What Is It?” exhibit; Charles Tripp, performing everyday tasks with his toes, became the “Armless Wonder” ([Bogdan 1988](#)). Attendees at freak shows could reassure themselves of their own normalcy as they observed the display of freakish others ([Garland-Thomson 1997](#); [Clare 1999](#)). The complex web of power relations staged by freak shows generated that which was abnormal, delineated that which was normal, and depended on embodied “evidence.” Here and elsewhere, the project of enforcing normalcy had particularly profound ramifications for disabled people, who were increasingly positioned by experts and laypeople alike as having abnormal bodies ([L. Davis 1995](#)).

The emergence of “unsightly beggar laws” in urban areas in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries (laws that prohibited “diseased, maimed, or unsightly” bodies from being in public spaces) likewise functioned to spatialize a distinction between normal citizens and those whose bodies or behavior marked them as deviant and in need of correction. Disability activists later termed these ordinances “ugly laws,” recognizing the extent to which they could be, or had been, deployed to control or contain people with disabilities ([Schweik 2009](#)). Such containment was often quite literal, as the rate of institutionalization of disabled people skyrocketed as the nineteenth century ended ([Trent 1994](#)). The move to displace individuals and populations deemed abnormal reached its most lethal conclusion in eugenic policies that flourished at the turn of the twentieth century. In both Europe and the United States, these policies encouraged the sterilization of disabled people, with the explicit goal and justification of extending

normalcy for future generations ([Snyder and Mitchell 2006](#)). In Nazi Germany, the phrase “life unworthy of life” was eventually used to describe disabled people, and thousands were killed alongside millions of Jewish people and others (homosexuals, gypsies, religious minorities, political dissidents) who went beyond the confines of the new eugenic normal ([Garland-Thomson 2007](#)).

By the mid-twentieth century, scholars had begun to map and critique the contours of normal and abnormal and the mechanisms used to divide one from the other. Foucault's former teacher Georges Canguilhem, a philosopher and historian of science, traced the ways that the biological, scientific, and statistical division of the world into “normal” and “pathological” was always saturated with political and ideological concerns and never entailed simple or neutral measurement (1966/1989). Erving Goffman studied the workings of stigma and argued that people with “spoiled identities,” outside the realm of the normal, had to manage, fastidiously, their encounters with others (1963). This management might be what Goffman called “stigmaphobic” (if one essentially insisted on one's normalcy and distanced oneself from more deviant others) or “stigmaphilic” (if one embraced, or even reveled in, one's outsider status), but it was constant.

Anzaldúa and other feminists, particularly feminists of color in the in the 1970s and 1980s, extended these early efforts toward a critical understanding of normalization, focusing on how regimes of normalcy were constructed through overlapping and mutually reinforcing systems of age, race, class, gender, and embodiment ([Moraga and Anzaldúa 1981](#); [B. Smith 1982](#); [Ferguson 2004](#)). “Somewhere on the edge of consciousness,” Audre Lorde wrote, “there is what I call a mythical norm, which each one of us within our hearts knows ‘that is not me.’ In america, this norm is usually defined as white, thin, male, young, heterosexual, christian, and financially secure” (1984a, 116). Disability studies scholars surveyed the uneven and unequal ways that bodies had been cast as normal and abnormal, and perhaps most famously, the interdisciplinary field of queer studies began to excavate the ways that normal was both naturalized as “heterosexual” and made compulsory ([Rich 1980/1983](#); [de Lauretis 1991](#); [M. Warner 1999](#)). By the end of the century, queer disability studies began to posit that “compulsory heterosexuality” was thoroughly interwoven with “compulsory able-bodiedness” ([McRuer 2006](#); [McRuer and Wilkerson 2003](#)).

In the same period, feminist and queer theory more generally began to rename “compulsory heterosexuality” as “heteronormativity” in order to convey the ways in which technologies of normalization operate not simply through logics of repression or compulsion but through forms of power that privilege, naturalize, and institutionalize heterosexuality ([Berlant and Warner 1998](#)). Eventually, queer theory moved from a textured delineation of the workings of “heteronormativity” to accounts of the ways in which gay men and lesbians themselves participate in what was dubbed “homonormativity,” especially as the organizations running the mainstream movement began to seem more and more like corporations and to emphasize disproportionately integrationist issues such as the right to marry or serve in the military ([Duggan 2002](#)). Transgender theorists, in turn, insisted that homonormativity consisted not only in contemporary gay and lesbian desires for normalcy and assimilation but also in a privileging of normative masculine and feminine experiences and embodiments ([Stryker 2008](#); [Spade 2011](#)).

Normal ways of being and living have generally been accorded a privacy denied to abnormal lives; that privacy has been secured through social forms such as the heterosexual (and reproductive) couple. Resistant alternatives to regimes of the normal thus argue for forms of being-in-common that are public, accessible, and collective. This expansive sense of public culture, which might be comprehended as both queer and disabled (or “crip,” as some scholars have begun to theorize it), are particularly vital now, because conceptualizations of “normal” have shifted during an era of neoliberal capitalism. [Brian Massumi](#)

(2002a), Slavoj Žižek (2010), and other critical theorists have argued that contemporary capitalism no longer deploys a logic of “totalizing normality”; instead, neoliberal capitalism focuses on and markets constant change, flexibility, “difference,” and, indeed, freakiness. Put differently, neoliberal capitalism arguably embraces the freaky or abnormal, domesticating or taming it as it sells it back to us. The more expansive and accessible public cultures offered by feminist, queer, and disability theorists seek to recognize and resist this embrace as just one more form of normalization (and indeed privatization), blocking a more democratic materialization of queer, freaky, and crip public cultures.

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